Application prep — United States: 9 universities

Sample — anonymized demo. This is a real end-to-end search with the student's identity removed (name changed, school and personal finances generalized). It shows the format and depth you get, not a real person's private file.

> **How to use this guide.** This is your **action list** for applying to these universities — the deadlines, tests, essays, fees, and financial-aid forms, with the shared work grouped so you do it once. It is *not* a "which university is best for me?" guide (that's your university reports). Work top to bottom: begin with **Start here**, read the strategy, then work each checklist. **Don't know a term? Tap it — every piece of jargon links to its plain-English meaning in Key terms at the back.** Use the Contents to jump around.

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Start here — your next 6 actions

1. **If you have no SAT score yet, register for the 7 Nov 2026 sitting by 23 Oct 2026** (late registration closes 27 Oct and costs extra). Seven of your nine universities require the SAT or

ACT, and 7 Nov is the last sitting that still works for an early application to MIT, Harvard, Yale or Penn. It also leaves you a second try on 5 Dec (register by 20 Nov).

2. **Choose your one early application by 25 Oct 2026.** The early deadline is 1 Nov 2026 everywhere. Recommendation: **Princeton SCEA** (need-blind, and no SAT needed this cycle) or **MIT Early Action** (need-blind, SAT by 30 Nov). Everything else goes Regular Decision.
3. **Ask your parents this week for their 2025 income and tax documents, with an English translation of each.** Every aid form below needs them, and this is the step families are slowest on. If they do not file tax, they need an employer letter stating annual income instead.
4. **Open your CSS Profile account now** (it opened 1 Oct 2026). Seven of the nine use it. Princeton and Yale do not ask you for it, so do not pay to send it to them.
5. **Tick "applying for financial aid" on every single application.** At Penn, Columbia, Cornell, Brown and Stanford you can never add it later, for all four years.
6. **Confirm your three recommenders:** your college counselor and two teachers, one of them maths or science. The same three cover all nine applications.

Snapshot

- **Region:** United States
- **Universities:** 9
- **Common App:** Princeton University, Harvard University, Yale University, Brown University, Stanford University, University of Pennsylvania (UPenn), Columbia University, Cornell University
- **MIT application (own portal, NOT Common App):** Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)
- **MYR conversions use:** USD 1 ≈ RM 4.04 (as of 2026-09-05 (the rate the list is built on))

United States application strategy

The set: 9 US universities through **2 systems**. **8 are on the Common App** (Princeton, Harvard, Yale, Brown, Stanford, Penn, Columbia, Cornell) and **MIT uses its own portal**.

Read on 12 October 2026. Every date, fee and form below was re-read on the university's own pages that day. Anything I could not confirm is marked ⚠ or "confirm". The English-test rules and the Stanford and Yale essays were re-read on 16 October.

> **One honest caveat (your call):** all 9 are **extreme Reaches**, with single-digit admit rates. There is no Match or Safety in this US set. The realistic-odds balance comes from your other regions. Applying is still worth it because, at your family's income, the aid makes most of them close to free **if** you are admitted.

1. You get ONE early card, and it is due 1 Nov 2026

Every early round closes on **1 November 2026**. The rules stop you stacking them:

- **Restrictive, non-binding (pick at most ONE):** Princeton **SCEA** · Harvard **REA** · Yale **SCEA** · Stanford **REA**. Each bars an early application to any other private US university.
- **MIT Early Action** is not restrictive on MIT's side, but MIT requires you to respect the other school's rule. So it cannot be paired with the four above.
- **Binding Early Decision:** Brown · Columbia · Cornell · Penn. If admitted you must enrol and withdraw everything else, before you have seen a single other aid offer. **Use it only if that university is your clear first choice.**

What your SAT status rules out. With no score in hand today:

- **Still open:** Princeton SCEA (no test needed) · MIT EA (sit 7 Nov) · Harvard REA (November scores accepted) · Yale SCEA (November scores usually arrive in time) · Penn ED (7 Nov is its last SAT date) · Columbia ED (no test needed).
- **Closed:** Stanford REA and Brown ED both needed an October sitting.

Recommendation: spend the early card on Princeton SCEA or MIT Early Action. Both are need-blind, so asking for aid cannot hurt you, and neither binds you. Send everything else Regular Decision.

2. Tests: seven require the SAT or ACT

- **Required:** MIT · Stanford · Harvard · Yale · Penn · Brown · Cornell.
- **Test-optional for Fall 2027 entry:** Princeton and Columbia. Both bring the requirement back for the 2027-28 cycle, so this is the last optional year.
- **Remaining SAT dates: 7 Nov 2026** (register by 23 Oct) and **5 Dec 2026** (register by 20 Nov). The next one after that is March 2027, too late for every deadline here.
- **Scores are self-reported** on the application everywhere except Princeton, which says SAT and ACT scores must come directly from the testing agency.

English test: check this, do not assume it. Each university waives IELTS or TOEFL only after a set number of years taught in English, and the number differs:

- **Yale:** 2 years or more at an English-medium school.
- **Princeton and Penn:** 3 years or more.
- **Cornell:** English as your main language of instruction for the past 4 years.
- **MIT:** recommends a test if you have used English for under 5 years.
- **Columbia:** all of secondary school taught in English, or SAT Reading and Writing 700+.
- **Brown:** not required, but highly recommended unless all of secondary school was in English.
- **Harvard and Stanford:** no English test required.

Two years of A-Levels alone clears Yale's rule, and Harvard and Stanford ask for none. It does not clear the others. **Count your English-medium years including secondary school.** You need IELTS Academic for Singapore, Australia and the UK anyway, so one sitting settles this whole question.

3. Aid: always ask for it, and know the two tiers

What "100% of need" is 100% of: the **cost of attendance**, the university's whole yearly price, not tuition alone. For your nine that is **USD 92,760 to 99,994 a year (about RM 375,000 to RM 404,000)**. MIT is cheapest, Brown dearest. Your **demonstrated need** is that figure minus what your family is judged able to pay. On the income in your file (a lower-income band) you sit below every published zero-parent-contribution line: USD 60,000 at Brown, 66,000 at Columbia, 100,000 at MIT, Harvard, Yale and Stanford, 150,000 at Princeton.

⚠️ Those lines are written for US families "with typical assets". Stanford says outright that the same levels "may not apply to families living outside of the United States". Each university sets your family's figure from the documents you send. A second property or a family business can raise it.

"Free" still leaves you a share. Most expect you to earn part of it:

- **MIT:** USD 5,400 a year (about RM 22,000).
- **Stanford:** at least USD 5,000 (about RM 20,000).
- **Yale:** USD 3,700 (about RM 15,000).
- **Harvard:** USD 3,500 (about RM 14,000).
- **Penn, Brown, Columbia:** a campus job is part of the package, amount not published.
- **Cornell:** a campus job, and possibly a loan.
- **Princeton:** ⚠️ its own pages disagree. See its entry.

The US visa and SEVIS fees are always yours.

The two tiers, by whether asking can cost you the place:

- **Need-blind for international students (ask freely): MIT · Princeton · Harvard · Yale · Brown.**
- **Need-aware (how much aid you need is weighed in the decision): Stanford · Penn · Columbia · Cornell.** Still request it. You need it, and at all four you can never add it later. A Malaysian sponsor such as Yayasan Khazanah matters most for these four.

4. Fees: about USD 750 if you pay them all, about USD 0 with waivers

Application fees: Stanford 100 · Harvard 95 · Columbia 85 · Cornell 85 · Brown 80 · Yale 80 · Penn 75 · MIT 75 · Princeton 75. That is **USD 750 (about RM 3,000)** in total.

Every one of the nine waives its fee for financial hardship, and a waiver does not count against you. Tick the fee-waiver question in the Common App and ask your college counselor to confirm it online. Princeton also has its own waiver that needs no counselor sign-off.

The CSS Profile is the fee you cannot easily waive. College Board charges about USD 25 for the first university and USD 16 for each one after. For your seven that is about **USD 121 (about RM 490)**. Brown and Cornell both say international applicants get no waiver. Stanford offers a free alternative form if you cannot pay.

5. Financial-aid forms cheat-sheet

University	Form	Code	Due if early	Due if regular
Princeton	PFAA only, free. No CSS Profile	none	9 Nov 2026	1 Feb 2027
Harvard	CSS Profile + IDOC	3434	1 Nov 2026	1 Feb 2027
Yale	Tick aid on the application. Yale then emails you its own steps	none	1 Dec 2026	15 Feb 2027
Brown	CSS Profile. IDOC if asked	3189	2 Nov 2026	1 Feb 2027
Stanford	CSS Profile or ISAFA, plus Stanford's International Student Supplement	4704	15 Nov 2026	15 Feb 2027
Penn	CSS Profile. Documents go to Penn's own portal, not IDOC	2933	6 Nov 2026	5 Feb 2027
Columbia	CSS Profile	2116	15 Nov 2026	15 Feb 2027
Cornell	CSS Profile. IDOC when asked	2098	**1 Nov 2026**	**2 Jan 2027**
MIT	CSS Profile + IDOC	3514	30 Nov 2026	15 Feb 2027

Cornell is the trap: its aid form is due the same day as the application, not a month later.

Visa & immigration

You apply for the visa only **after** you accept an offer, so nothing here is due before May 2027. Read it now so the costs and the lead time do not surprise you.

The visa and who issues it

- The **F-1** student visa, issued by the US Embassy in Kuala Lumpur.
- Your university first registers you in SEVIS and sends you a Form **I-20**. You cannot book a visa interview without it.

The steps, in order

- Reply to your offer by **1 May 2027**. The university then asks how you will fund year one and issues the I-20.
- Pay the **SEVIS I-901 fee: USD 350** (about RM 1,400) at fmjfee.com.
- Fill in the US State Department's online visa form, the DS-160, and pay the **visa application fee: USD 185** (about RM 750).

- Attend an interview at the Embassy. Interviews are generally required. The Kuala Lumpur embassy says waivers are granted only in extreme situations.
- The Embassy instructs every F visa applicant to set their social media accounts to **public** for vetting. Do this before you submit.

Timing

- A visa for a new student can be issued up to **365 days** before your programme starts.
- You may not enter the United States more than **30 days** before the start date.
- Interview waiting times vary by season. Book as soon as the I-20 arrives; do not leave it until July.

Financial proof

- You must show how you will pay all educational, living and travel costs.
- Your **financial-aid award letter** is the main evidence. Whatever it does not cover, your share and your flights, is shown with a bank statement or a sponsor letter.
- The exact amount is printed on your I-20. It is that university's first-year cost of attendance minus its grant.

Cost

- **USD 535 in total (about RM 2,200)** before flights: SEVIS 350 plus visa 185.
- ⚠️ A further **USD 250 "visa integrity fee"** was written into US law in 2025. The State Department's fee page did not list it on 12 Oct 2026. Check that page again before you pay.

Work while you study

- On campus: up to 20 hours a week during term, the standing F-1 rule. Your campus job counts.
- Off campus: not allowed in your first academic year. After that, only with authorisation, as CPT or OPT.

The post-study route: the paperwork

- **OPT** gives 12 months of work in your field. Your university's international office recommends you, then you file Form I-765 with USCIS.
- File it up to **90 days before** you finish and no later than **60 days after**, and within 30 days of the university's recommendation. You cannot start work until the card arrives.
- **STEM OPT** adds 24 months for a qualifying engineering degree, but only with an employer on E-Verify. File up to 90 days before your first OPT ends.
- The filing fee is on USCIS's Fee Schedule page. It was re-priced for inflation on 16 Oct 2026, so check it the year you file.

⚠️ **A rule in flux. Re-check it when your I-20 arrives.** On 17 July 2026 DHS published a final rule replacing the open-ended student stay with a **fixed period**: your programme length, capped at four years, plus 30 days. Under it, OPT and STEM OPT would each need a separate extension-of-stay application to USCIS, with a fee and fingerprints, and undergraduates could not change major or transfer in their first year. **On 14 September 2026 a US federal court postponed the rule.** USCIS says it "will proceed under the previous regulatory provisions" until the court decides. Nothing for you to do today. It does not change whether you may work after graduating. It may add paperwork and cost if it comes back.

Grouped by application system

On the cost figures. Every cost figure below is the university's published **2026-27** number, the most recent full year. You are applying for **Fall 2027** entry, and the 2027-28 figures usually publish around **March to April 2027**. Recent rises have been close to 4% a year: MIT went from USD 89,340 to 92,760, and Cornell's tuition rose 3.76%. Budget about **5% above** what you see here and re-check each cost page in spring. The aid *policies* are current for your cycle.

Common App

Universities: Princeton University, Harvard University, Yale University, Brown University, Stanford University, University of Pennsylvania (UPenn), Columbia University, Cornell University.

Filed once across these schools:

- ☐ Create your **Common App account** and add all eight universities.
- ☐ Write the **Common App personal essay** (up to about 650 words). One essay serves all eight.
- ☐ Ask your college counselor for the **School Report + counselor recommendation**.
- ☐ Ask **two teachers** for recommendations. One must be a maths or science teacher: Brown and Columbia Engineering both require it.
- ☐ Have your college send your **official transcript + predicted A-Level grades**.
- ☐ Arrange the **mid-year report** with your college for February 2027.
- ☐ Answer each university's **own supplement questions**. The prompts are live inside the Common App now.
- ☐ **Self-report your SAT** in the testing section, for the six Common App universities that take self-reported scores.
- ☐ Tick the **fee-waiver** question and ask your counselor to confirm it online.
- ☐ Tick **"applying for financial aid"** on all eight.

1. Princeton University — Reach — need-blind for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** SCEA **2026-11-01** · Regular Decision **2027-01-01**. Decisions mid-December / late March.
- **Financial-aid deadline:** PFAA due **2026-11-09** (SCEA) or **2027-02-01** (Regular Decision).

b. Tests

- **Test-optional** for Fall 2027 entry. Princeton requires the SAT or ACT again from the 2027-28 cycle.
- If you do submit: sit it by the October date for SCEA or the December date for Regular Decision. Princeton says scores must come **directly from the testing agency**, not self-reported.
- IELTS or TOEFL is required unless you have spent **at least three years** at a secondary school taught in English. Count your years.

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay** + the **Princeton-specific questions**.
- A **graded written paper**, in English, preferably from English or history. Ask a teacher for a marked essay now.

d. Application fee

- **USD 75** (about RM 300). ⚠ That is the 2025-26 figure; I could not find a 2026-27 one. The Common App shows the live amount.
- Waived for hardship if you are applying for aid. International students are eligible. Princeton's own waiver needs no counselor sign-off.

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model** — **Need-blind for international students.** Asking for aid does not affect the decision. Princeton says the full need of admitted international students is met "the same as it is for students from the United States".
- **Cost** — **USD 94,624 a year** for a first-year (**about RM 382,000**): tuition 68,140 · housing 13,010 · food 9,110 · fees 314 · books 1,050 · personal 3,000. Travel is added on top, USD 50 to 5,000 by home address. The Student Health Plan is a further USD 4,220 (about RM 17,000) unless you have comparable cover; aid is available for it.
- **Covers** — For families earning up to **USD 150,000** with typical assets, Princeton's published family contribution is **zero**. Against the USD 94,624 that means tuition, housing, food, books and personal expenses, as **grant with no loans**. ⚠ The table is built on US-resident families. Yours is set from your own documents.
- **Your share**
  - ⚠ **Princeton's pages disagree, so ask.** Its 2022 announcement removed the USD 3,500 student contribution for all undergraduates. Its aid FAQ still says it typically expects first-years "to work 9 hours per week". Email the aid office and ask which applies to your offer.

    - **Still yours:** the visa and SEVIS fees, and spending beyond the allowance.
    - Confirm whether the travel allowance stretches to a Kuala Lumpur airfare.
- **Forms** — The **Princeton Financial Aid Application (PFAA)** only. It is free and sits inside your Princeton applicant portal. **Princeton does not use the CSS Profile or IDOC at all**, so do not pay to send it one.
- **Documents**
    - Your parents' tax return covering most of **2025**: the original plus a full certified English translation, uploaded after you submit the PFAA.
    - If they do not file tax: a non-filer statement instead.
    - Upload through the portal. Email is not accepted.
- **Dates** — You get portal access only after you submit the admission application, so apply first, then file the PFAA.

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Submit the Common App + Princeton-specific questions
- ☐ Upload a graded written paper
- ☐ Counselor recommendation + School Report + 2 teacher recommendations
- ☐ Transcript + predicted grades
- ☐ Decide whether to send an SAT score (optional this cycle)
- ☐ Request the fee waiver
- ☐ File the PFAA in the applicant portal, then upload the 2025 tax documents

Portal: https://admission.princeton.edu/apply · aid: https://finaid.princeton.edu/apply-aid-prospective-students

2. Harvard University — Reach — need-blind for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** REA **2026-11-01** · Regular Decision **2027-01-01**. Decisions mid-December / end of March.
- **Financial-aid deadline: 2026-11-01** (REA) or **2027-02-01** (Regular Decision). CSS Profile + IDOC.

b. Tests

- **SAT or ACT required.**
- REA: scores by end of October are preferred, but Harvard accepts the **November** sitting if needed.
- Regular Decision: November or earlier is preferred; the **December SAT** is accepted.
- Self-reported. Official scores only if you enrol.
- Harvard's requirements page lists no English-test requirement. Confirm this with Admissions if your earlier schooling was not in English.

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay** + the **Harvard College Questions**: five required short answers, 150 words each.

d. Application fee

- **USD 95** (about RM 380), or a fee waiver.
- Harvard says the fee "will be waived" if it is a hardship, and that asking will not disadvantage you. Request it in the Common App.

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model** — **Need-blind for international students.** Harvard says international students "are eligible for exactly the same aid as American students".
- **Cost** — **USD 91,634 a year billed** (**about RM 370,000**): tuition 62,226 · fees 6,216 · housing 14,250 · food 8,942. Adding personal (2,500), books (1,000) and travel (0 to 5,000) gives **USD 95,134 to 100,134** (**about RM 384,000 to RM 405,000**). Health insurance is a further USD 4,954 (about RM 20,000) unless a family plan covers you.
- **Covers** — For families earning **USD 100,000 or less** with typical assets, Harvard is free: aid covers all billed costs, **plus health insurance if you need it, travel between home and campus, and winter gear**. You also get a **USD 2,000 start-up grant** (about RM 8,100) in year one and a **USD 2,000 launch grant** in your third year. No loans. This is the most complete offer of your nine.
- **Your share**
  - **USD 3,500 a year** (about RM 14,000) for personal expenses, usually earned through a term-time campus job.
  - Harvard's page names no summer-work expectation.
  - **Still yours:** the visa and SEVIS fees.
- **Forms** — **CSS Profile** (Harvard's code is **3434**) + **IDOC**. IDOC only opens after the CSS Profile is submitted.
- **Documents**
  - Both parents' **2025** income tax documents, as filed with the Malaysian government, **translated into English**. Filed returns only, no drafts.
  - If your parents do not file: a Tax Non-Filer Statement plus a wage statement or employer letter showing annual income.
  - Your own 2025 tax document, or a non-filer statement.
- **Dates** — The CSS fee waiver built into the form is for US students. If you cannot pay it, Harvard links an alternative set of instructions on its aid page.

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Submit the Common App + the five Harvard College Questions
- ☐ Counselor letter + School Report + 2 teacher recommendations
- ☐ Transcript + predicted grades, then the Midyear School Report
- ☐ Self-report the SAT

- ☐ Request the fee waiver
- ☐ File the CSS Profile (code 3434)
- ☐ Upload parents' 2025 tax documents to IDOC, with English translations

Portal: https://college.harvard.edu/admissions/apply/first-year-applicants · aid: https://college.harvard.edu/financial-aid/apply-financial-aid/prospective-students

3. Yale University — Reach — need-blind for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** SCEA **2026-11-01** · Regular Decision **2027-01-02**. Decisions mid-December / late March.
- **Financial-aid deadline:** International applicants: **2026-12-01** (SCEA) or **2027-02-15** (Regular Decision). A late aid application does not reduce your offer.

b. Tests

- **SAT or ACT required** of every first-year applicant. AP or IB results are optional extras, not a substitute.
- SCEA: October or November sittings are generally in time. Regular Decision: the 5 Dec SAT is comfortably in time.
- Self-reported. Official scores only if you are admitted.
- An English test is required unless you have **two or more years** at an English-medium school. Your A-Levels meet that.

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay** + **Yale's own questions** for the 2026-27 cycle, in the Common App.
- Pick up to **three academic areas**, then write **200 words or fewer** on a topic in one of them that excites you.
- **Three short takes**, 200 characters each (about 35 words). Answer all three.
- **One essay of 400 words or fewer**, choosing one of three prompts.

d. Application fee

- **USD 80** (about RM 320).
- Yale issues no waiver of its own. It comes through the Common App fee-waiver question, confirmed by your counselor.

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model** — **Need-blind for international students.** Yale meets 100% of demonstrated need "regardless of citizenship or immigration status".
- **Cost** — **USD 97,985 a year** (**about RM 396,000**): tuition 72,500 · housing 12,080 · food 9,520 · activity fee 185 · books 1,000 · personal 2,700. Travel is added on top: Yale includes the estimated cost of two return trips between your home and New Haven.

- **Covers** — Families earning **under USD 100,000** with typical assets often qualify for a **zero parent share**. The Yale Scholarship then covers **tuition, fees, housing, food and travel**, plus **hospitalisation insurance** and a **USD 2,000 start-up grant** (about RM 8,100) in year one. No loans in the initial offer.
- **Your share**
  - **The Student Share: USD 3,700 a year** (about RM 15,000). It is Yale's estimate of what you can earn from term-time and summer work.
  - Travel money is credited to your account, not paid to you separately.
  - **Still yours:** the visa and SEVIS fees.
- **Forms** — **Tick aid on your Common App.** Yale's aid office then contacts you directly with its own steps, from **mid-November** for early applicants. The CSS Profile is **not required** from international applicants unless Yale asks for it. Yale does not accept the ISFAA form.

⚠️ One Yale admissions page says the CSS Profile is required of all aid applicants. The aid office's own pages say international applicants do not file it unless asked. Follow the aid checklist in your Yale applicant portal, and ask the aid office if it lists the CSS Profile.

- **Documents** — Yale tells you what to send when it contacts you. Have your parents' **2025** income documents and English translations ready so you can answer the same week.

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Submit the Common App + Yale-specific questions
- ☐ Counselor recommendation + School Report + 2 teacher recommendations
- ☐ Transcript + predicted grades, then the Mid-Year Report
- ☐ Self-report the SAT
- ☐ Request the fee waiver through the Common App
- ☐ Tick "applying for financial aid", then watch your email for Yale's instructions

Portal: https://admissions.yale.edu/apply · aid: https://finaid.yale.edu/apply/prospective

4. Brown University — Reach — need-blind for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** Early Decision **2026-11-01** (binding) · Regular Decision **2027-01-05**.
  ⚠️ Your master list says 1 Jan; Brown's checklist says **5 Jan**.
- **Financial-aid deadline: 2026-11-02** (Early Decision) or **2027-02-01** (Regular Decision).

b. Tests

- **SAT or ACT required.** Brown superscores.
- Early Decision needs testing done by the **last October date**, which has passed. Regular Decision: by the last December date, so the **5 Dec SAT** works.
- Self-reported. Official scores only if you enrol.

- An English test is **not required**, but Brown **highly recommends** one unless all of your secondary school was taught in English. Brown sets no number of years. If you do send one: IELTS 8.0 or Duolingo 130.

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay** + **Brown's supplemental essays**, submitted through the Common App.

d. Application fee

- **USD 80** (about RM 320), or a fee waiver.

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model** — **Need-blind for international first-years**, starting with the Class of 2029. The page sets no end date, so it covers your entry year. ⚠ Re-confirm it before you commit to a binding Early Decision.
- **Cost** — **USD 99,994 a year** (**about RM 404,000**), the highest of your nine: tuition 74,568 · fees 3,084 · housing 10,710 · food 8,754 · personal 2,878. A travel allowance by home address is added on top. Books are covered separately for scholarship students.
- **Covers** — Brown "meets 100% of each student's demonstrated financial need" with **no loans**. For most families earning **under USD 60,000** the parent share is **zero**, which on your file means grant against close to the whole USD 99,994.
- **Your share**
  - Brown expects you to use part of your **summer earnings** and to hold a **term-time job**. ⚠ It publishes no dollar figure. Ask for yours with the offer.
  - **Still yours:** the visa and SEVIS fees.
- **Forms** — **CSS Profile**, Brown's code **3189**. **Brown gives no CSS fee waiver.** It does not accept the ISFAA or a paper form.
- **Documents**
  - After you file, College Board may email an **IDOC** request: parents' tax returns or non-filer statements, and employer earnings statements if no return is filed.
  - If your parents are divorced or separated, each files a CSS Profile.
- **Dates** — Request aid when you apply. Brown meets full need only for students who "apply for financial aid at the time they apply for admission".

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Submit the Common App + Brown supplemental essays
- ☐ Counselor recommendation + School Report, invited separately in the Common App
- ☐ 2 teacher recommendations, at least one maths or science
- ☐ Transcript + predicted grades
- ☐ Send the mid-year report by 27 Feb 2027
- ☐ Self-report the SAT
- ☐ Request the fee waiver

- ☐ File the CSS Profile (code 3189) and answer any IDOC request

Portal: https://admission.brown.edu/first-year/application-checklist · aid: https://finaid.brown.edu/apply/first-year-international

5. Stanford University — Reach — need-AWARE for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** REA **2026-11-01** · Regular Decision **2027-01-05**. Decisions mid-December / early April.
- **Financial-aid deadline:** Priority date **2026-11-15** (REA) or **2027-02-15** (Regular Decision).

b. Tests

- **SAT or ACT required.**
- REA needs the SAT by the **end of October**, which has passed. Regular Decision: by the end of December, so the **5 Dec SAT** works.
- Self-reported. Official scores only if you enrol.
- An English test cannot stand in for the SAT. Stanford's testing page sets no English-test requirement of its own.

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay** + **Stanford's own questions**, answered in the Common App once you add Stanford.
- **Five short questions**, 3 to 50 words each.
- **Three short essays**, 100 to 250 words each. One of them is a note to your future roommate.
- Stanford does not accept new or updated essays once you submit, so finish them first.

d. Application fee

- **USD 100** (about RM 400), the highest of your nine.
- Stanford accepts the Common App fee waiver from non-US applicants. Tick it and ask your counselor to verify online. You need not wait for approval before you submit.

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model** — **Need-aware.** Stanford says it has "a limited amount of financial aid for international students", so how much you need can count. Still ask: an international student who does not request aid at admission "will not be eligible to apply for aid" for the whole degree.
- **Cost** — **USD 97,545 a year** (**about RM 394,000**): tuition 67,731 · housing and food 22,944 · fees 2,610 · books 855 · personal 3,405. Travel is added on top.
- **Covers** — For parents earning **under USD 100,000** with typical assets, Stanford expects **no parent contribution**. ⚠️ Stanford adds that these levels "may not apply to families living outside of the United States". Your figure is set case by case.

- **Your share**
  - **At least USD 5,000 a year** (about RM 20,000): typically USD 1,500 from summer earnings and USD 3,500 from a term-time job of 8 to 10 hours a week.
  - Plus 5% of any savings in your own name.
  - **Still yours:** the visa and SEVIS fees.
- **Forms**
  - **CSS Profile**, Stanford's code **4704**.
  - If you cannot pay the CSS fee: the **ISAFA** instead, sent through Stanford's Document Upload. Do not send both.
  - Stanford's **International Student Supplement** form, also through Document Upload.
- **Documents** — Parents' income documents, uploaded to Stanford. If your parents are separated, each files their own CSS Profile.
- **Dates** — Say on the admission application that you are applying for aid. Offers arrive in April for Regular Decision.

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Submit the Common App + Stanford questions
- ☐ Counselor letter + School Report + 2 teacher recommendations
- ☐ Transcript + predicted grades
- ☐ Send the midyear transcript by 15 Feb 2027
- ☐ Self-report the SAT
- ☐ Request the fee waiver
- ☐ File the CSS Profile (code 4704), or the ISAFA if you cannot pay
- ☐ Upload the International Student Supplement

Portal: https://admission.stanford.edu/apply/first-year/ · aid: https://financialaid.stanford.edu/undergrad/apply/index.html

6. University of Pennsylvania (UPenn) — Reach — need-AWARE for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** Early Decision **2026-11-01** (binding) · Regular Decision **2027-01-05**. Decisions December / April.
- **Financial-aid deadline: 2026-11-06** (Early Decision) or **2027-02-05** (Regular Decision) to get your aid offer with your decision. **Aid must be requested with the application.**

b. Tests

- **SAT or ACT required.** A hardship waiver can be requested inside the application.
- Latest SAT: **7 Nov 2026** for Early Decision, **5 Dec 2026** for Regular Decision.
- Self-reported. Official scores only if admitted.

- English test waived only if English was your main language of instruction for **at least three years** by the time you enrol. Count your years. English scores cannot be self-reported.

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay** + **Penn's own essays**. The prompts are in the Common App.

d. Application fee

- **USD 75** (about RM 300).
- Waived through the Common App if the fee is a significant burden.

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model** — **Need-aware** for everyone who is not a citizen or permanent resident of the US, Canada or Mexico. Penn puts "over $10 million each year" into aid for these students.
- **Cost** — **USD 99,082 a year** living on campus (**about RM 400,000**): tuition 65,670 · fees 8,308 · housing 13,644 · food 6,960 · books 1,412 · transportation 1,080 · personal 2,008.
- **Covers** — If you are admitted with aid, Penn "commits to meet 100% of [your] demonstrated need with grant funds and work-study", against that USD 99,082. No loans in the package.
- **Your share**
  - A **campus job** is part of every package. ⚠️ Penn does not publish the amount. Ask for your figure with the offer.
  - ⚠️ Part of a Penn grant may be **taxed in the US**, and Penn will not top up the grant to cover that tax. You may recover some by filing a US tax return each year.
  - **Still yours:** the visa and SEVIS fees.
- **Forms** — **CSS Profile**, Penn's code **2933**. **Penn does not use IDOC.** Anything sent there never reaches Penn.
- **Documents**
  - Parents' tax return: **the original and an English translation**, uploaded to Penn's Document Submission Portal. Not by email.
  - Convert ringgit amounts to US dollars.
  - If your parents do not file: a wage statement, pay slip or employer letter on letterhead, plus Penn's Non-Tax Filer Form.
  - Information is required from both biological parents.
- **Dates** — **Critical:** a student not admitted with aid in year one is "not eligible to apply for financial aid at a later point".

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Submit the Common App + Penn essays
- ☐ Counselor recommendation + School Report + 2 teacher recommendations
- ☐ Transcript + predicted grades
- ☐ Self-report the SAT
- ☐ Request the fee waiver

- ☐ File the CSS Profile (code 2933) with the application
- ☐ Upload parents' tax documents + translations to Penn's own portal

Portal: https://admissions.upenn.edu/how-to-apply/first-year-applicants · aid: https://srfs.upenn.edu/financial-aid/apply/prospective-UG-checklists/international

7. Columbia University — Reach — need-AWARE for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** Early Decision **2026-11-01** (binding) · Regular Decision **2027-01-01**. Decisions mid-December / late March.
- **Financial-aid deadline: 2026-11-15** (Early Decision) or **2027-02-15** (Regular Decision).

b. Tests

- **Test-optional for Fall 2027 entry.** Columbia: applicants in the 2026-2027 cycle "may choose whether or not to submit testing". It requires the SAT or ACT from the 2027-28 cycle.
- If you do submit: tests as late as November 2026 (Early Decision) or February 2027 (Regular Decision). Self-reported, and superscored.
- Columbia says exam results needed to finish secondary school **must** be submitted, and names A-Levels. Send yours when they arrive.
- An English test is required **unless all of your secondary school was taught in English**, or you score **700+ on SAT Reading and Writing**. Otherwise: IELTS 7.5. Count your years.

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay** + the **Columbia-specific questions**.
- No interviews.

d. Application fee

- **USD 85** (about RM 340).
- An automatic fee waiver can be requested inside the application if the fee is a significant burden.

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model** — **Need-aware.** For international applicants the committee "takes into consideration how much financial aid a student requires". Asking can lengthen your odds. Not asking is worse: you can never add it.
- **Cost** — **USD 99,774 a year** (**about RM 403,000**), including books 1,320 and personal 1,844. Tuition is 72,800. Travel varies: Columbia budgets two return flights a year.
- **Covers**
  - For admitted international students Columbia meets **100% of demonstrated need** with a grant and a campus job. **No loans.**
  - Families earning **under USD 66,000** with typical assets: **zero parent contribution** against that USD 99,774.

    - Under USD 150,000: tuition-free.
    - A **USD 2,000 start-up grant** (about RM 8,100) for first-years from low-income families.
    - The average international award is USD 79,375 (about RM 321,000).
  - **Your share**
    - A **campus job** is part of the package. ⚠️ No dollar figure on the pages I read. Ask with the offer.
    - **Still yours:** the visa and SEVIS fees.
- **Forms** — **CSS Profile**, code **2116**, listed as "Columbia U: College & Engineering". Columbia has several codes. The wrong one means your form never arrives.
- **Documents** — Parents' income documents. A CSS Profile is needed from both parents.
- **Dates** — **Irreversible:** international students admitted without requesting aid "may not change their status to apply for aid at any time during their four years". Only a severe, unforeseen change is reviewed, case by case.

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Submit the Common App + Columbia-specific questions
- ☐ Counselor recommendation + school profile
- ☐ 2 teacher recommendations, one from a maths or science teacher (Engineering rule)
- ☐ Transcript + predicted grades, then the midyear report
- ☐ Decide whether to send an SAT score (optional this cycle)
- ☐ Request the fee waiver
- ☐ Tick "applying for financial aid" on the application
- ☐ File the CSS Profile (code 2116)

Portal: https://undergrad.admissions.columbia.edu/apply/firstyear · aid: https://undergrad.admissions.columbia.edu/apply/international/aid

8. Cornell University — Reach — need-AWARE for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** Early Decision **2026-11-01** (binding) · Regular Decision **2027-01-02**. Other materials by 13 Nov / 19 Jan. Decisions mid-December / late March.
- **Financial-aid deadline:** International applicants: **2026-11-01** (Early Decision) or **2027-01-02** (Regular Decision). **The same day as the application.**

b. Tests

- **SAT or ACT required.** Cornell takes your highest section scores across sittings.
- Self-reported. Official scores only if you enrol.
- An English test is required unless English has been your main language of instruction for the **past four years**. This is the strictest rule of your nine. ⚠️ Two years of A-Levels alone does not meet it.

c. Essays

- **Common App personal essay** + the **Cornell writing supplement**, with the College of Engineering's own essays.

d. Application fee

- **USD 85** (about RM 340).
- Waived if the fee is a burden and you plan to apply for aid. Answer "Yes" to the Common App question and Cornell's own waiver questions. No documents needed.

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model** — **Need-aware.** Cornell: need for aid is "one factor among many" in international decisions.
- **Cost** — **USD 99,734 a year** (**about RM 403,000**): tuition 73,946 · fees 1,024 · housing 13,744 · food 7,604 · books 1,234 · personal 2,182. Travel is added by region. ⚠️ Cornell's cost page labelled this table 2025-26, but the tuition and housing figures match the 2026-27 rates its trustees approved in March 2026.
- **Covers** — Cornell "meets 100 percent of admitted international undergraduates' demonstrated financial need", but **not all as grant**. The offer is Cornell grants, a campus-job award, and "reasonable student loans depending on total family income".
- **Your share**
  - A **campus job each year**, and **possibly a loan**. This is the softest package of your nine.
  - ⚠️ No dollar figures are published. You see them in the Cornell Aid Estimate after admission.
  - **Still yours:** the visa and SEVIS fees.
- **Forms** — **CSS Profile**, code **2098**, filed when you apply. International applicants generally get no CSS fee waiver. Fee-waiver requests go to intl-finaid@cornell.edu by the deadline.
- **Documents**
  - Cornell requests documents through **IDOC** after you file. Upload signed copies, and only what is asked for.
  - If your parents are divorced or separated, each files a CSS Profile.
- **Dates** — Miss the aid deadline and you cannot apply for Cornell aid at any point as an undergraduate.

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Submit the Common App + Cornell writing supplement
- ☐ Counselor recommendation + School Report + 2 teacher recommendations
- ☐ Transcript + predicted grades, then mid-year grades
- ☐ Self-report the SAT
- ☐ Sit IELTS or TOEFL unless you have four years of English-medium schooling
- ☐ Request the fee waiver
- ☐ File the CSS Profile (code 2098) on the same day as the application

Portal: https://admissions.cornell.edu/how-to-apply/first-year-applicants · aid: https://finaid.cornell.edu/first-year-and-transfer-students-international

MIT application (own portal, NOT Common App)

Universities: Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT).

Filed once across these schools:

- ☐ Apply on **MIT's own application** at mitadmissions.org. It is a separate account, not the Common App.
- ☐ Write **MIT's short-answer essays**. The Common App essay is not used.
- ☐ Ask for **two teacher letters:** one maths or science, one humanities, social science or language.
- ☐ Ask your counselor for the **Secondary School Report + transcript**.
- ☐ **Self-report the SAT or ACT** (required).
- ☐ Send the **February Updates & Notes form** with mid-year grades in mid-February 2027.

9. Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) — Reach — need-blind for internationals

a. Deadlines

- **Application deadline:** Early Action **2026-11-01** · Regular Action **2027-01-04** (MIT's name for Regular Decision). Decisions mid-December / mid-March.
- **Financial-aid deadline: 2026-11-30** (Early Action) or **2027-02-15** (Regular Action). CSS Profile + IDOC.

b. Tests

- **SAT or ACT required.** No cut-off and no recommended score.
- Sit it **before 30 Nov 2026** for Early Action, or **before 31 Dec 2026** for Regular Action. The 7 Nov and 5 Dec SATs both fit.
- Self-reported.
- An English test is strongly recommended only if you have used English for under five years.

c. Essays

- **MIT's own short-answer essays**, written in MIT's application. The Common App essay is not used.

d. Application fee

- **USD 75** (about RM 300), or a fee waiver.

e. Financial aid — cost, what's covered, forms, dates

- **Model — Need-blind for international students.** MIT: "we don't consider your ability to pay for college in the admissions process". Aid "never includes loans".

- **Cost** — **USD 92,760 a year** (**about RM 375,000**), the lowest of your nine: tuition 66,720 · housing 14,090 · food 8,104 · student life fee 420 · books 930 · personal 2,496. Travel is estimated from your home address and added on top. MIT's health plan is a further USD 5,148 (about RM 20,800) unless you prove comparable cover.
- **Covers** — For families earning **under USD 100,000** with typical assets, MIT says "parents can expect to pay nothing at all". Its median net price for that band in 2025-26 was **USD 0**. The MIT Scholarship is grant, never repaid. Its highest-need students also get a **USD 2,000 First Year Grant** (about RM 8,100) and a Health Insurance Grant.
- **Your share**
  - **USD 5,400 a year** (about RM 22,000): MIT's typical student contribution, from summer savings and a campus job. Campus jobs pay at least USD 15 an hour.
  - The first USD 5,400 of any outside scholarship replaces it entirely.
  - **Still yours:** the visa and SEVIS fees.
- **Forms** — **CSS Profile**, MIT's code **3514**, + **IDOC**.
- **Documents**
  - Your parents' tax returns or wage statements for **2025**, uploaded to IDOC, not sent to MIT.
  - Translate them into English if they are in Malay. MIT says professional translation is not required.
  - Allow up to two weeks for documents to reach MIT.
- **Dates** — Filing late brings a later answer, not a penalty. Offers arrive by email: mid-January for Early Action, mid-March for Regular Action.

f. What to gather / do

- ☐ Create an MIT application account (separate from the Common App)
- ☐ Write MIT's short-answer essays
- ☐ 2 teacher letters: one maths or science, one humanities
- ☐ Secondary School Report + transcript from your counselor
- ☐ Self-report the SAT
- ☐ Request the fee waiver
- ☐ File the CSS Profile (code 3514)
- ☐ Upload parents' 2025 tax documents to IDOC
- ☐ Send the February Updates & Notes form with mid-year grades

Portal: https://mitadmissions.org/apply/firstyear/ · aid: https://sfs.mit.edu/undergraduate-students/apply-for-aid/international/

Gather once (across the whole region)

- ☐ **Official transcript** + **predicted A-Level grades** (Maths, Further Maths, Physics, Chemistry).
- ☐ **Three recommenders:** your counselor (School Report) + **2 teachers**, one maths or science and one humanities or language. That mix satisfies MIT, Brown and Columbia at once.
- ☐ **SAT:** register by **23 Oct** for 7 Nov, or by **20 Nov** for 5 Dec. Send Princeton an official score report if you submit one there.
- ☐ **Count your years of English-medium schooling.** Unless all of secondary school was in English, sit **IELTS Academic** before January: Columbia needs it (or SAT Reading and Writing 700+), Cornell needs it under four years, Princeton and Penn under three, and Brown highly recommends it.
- ☐ **One Common App personal essay**, reused across eight, + each university's supplement + **MIT's own essays**.
- ☐ **A graded written paper** in English for Princeton.
- ☐ **Parents' 2025 income and tax documents, each with an English translation.** If they do not file tax: an employer letter stating annual income.
- ☐ **CSS Profile account:** add Harvard 3434 · Brown 3189 · Stanford 4704 · Penn 2933 · Columbia 2116 · Cornell 2098 · MIT 3514. Budget about USD 121.
- ☐ **Princeton's PFAA** in the Princeton portal, after you submit that application.
- ☐ **Fee-waiver confirmation** from your college counselor in the Common App. One confirmation serves all eight.
- ☐ **Passport** valid well past 2027, for the I-20 and visa step once admitted.

Deadline calendar

Date	What	Action
2026-10-23	SAT registration closes for the 7 Nov sitting	Register now if you have no score. Late registration closes 27 Oct and costs extra
2026-11-01	EARLY deadline, every university (pick ONE: Princeton SCEA / MIT EA / Harvard REA / Yale SCEA)	Submit your single early application
2026-11-01	Early aid deadline: Harvard REA · Cornell ED	File the CSS Profile the same day if this is your early choice
2026-11-02	Early aid deadline: Brown ED	CSS Profile, code 3189
2026-11-06	Early aid deadline: Penn ED	CSS Profile, code 2933, + documents to Penn's portal
2026-11-07	SAT sitting	Last one in time for MIT EA, Harvard REA, Yale SCEA and Penn ED

Date	What	Action
2026-11-09	Early aid deadline: Princeton SCEA	File the PFAA in the Princeton portal
2026-11-15	Early aid deadline: Stanford REA · Columbia ED	CSS Profile
2026-11-20	SAT registration closes for the 5 Dec sitting	Register for a first or second attempt
2026-11-30	MIT Early Action: SAT cut-off and aid deadline	Sit the SAT before today; CSS Profile + IDOC due
2026-12-01	Early aid deadline: Yale SCEA (international)	Answer Yale's aid instructions
2026-12-05	SAT sitting	Last one in time for Regular Decision
2026-12-31	MIT Regular Action SAT cut-off	Testing must be done before today
2027-01-01	Regular Decision: Princeton · Harvard · Columbia	Submit the Common App + supplements
2027-01-02	Regular Decision: Yale · Cornell. Cornell's aid form is due today too	Submit; file Cornell's CSS Profile (2098) the same day
2027-01-04	MIT Regular Action	Submit MIT's own application
2027-01-05	Regular Decision: Stanford · Penn · Brown	Submit; tick aid on all three
2027-02-01	Regular aid deadline: Princeton · Harvard · Brown	PFAA (Princeton); CSS Profile + IDOC (Harvard); CSS Profile (Brown)
2027-02-05	Regular aid deadline: Penn	CSS Profile + documents to Penn's portal
2027-02-15	Regular aid deadline: MIT · Stanford · Columbia · Yale	CSS Profile (+ IDOC for MIT); Stanford midyear transcript also due
2027-02-27	Brown mid-year report due	Ask your college to send it
2027-05-01	Reply date, all nine	Compare offers and aid, then accept one. The visa steps start here

Key terms

New to these? Here's what the shorthand in this guide means — tap a linked term anywhere below to jump back here.

- **ED** — **Early Decision** — apply early and, if admitted, you are *bound* to enrol and withdraw your other applications. Avoid it if you need to compare aid offers.

- **EA** — **Early Action** — apply early for an earlier decision; *non-binding*, so you stay free to compare offers and decline.
- **RD** — **Regular Decision** — the standard round with the normal (later) deadline; non-binding.
- **SCEA** — **Single-Choice Early Action** — a restrictive early option: non-binding, but you may not apply early to most *other* private universities at the same time.
- **REA** — **Restrictive Early Action** — like SCEA: non-binding early action that bars you from applying early to other private schools.
- **cost of attendance** — The university's official all-in yearly price — tuition **plus** housing, food, fees, books and personal expenses. This is the number financial aid is measured against, not the tuition figure alone.
- **demonstrated need** — Your cost of attendance minus what the university calculates your family can pay. "Meets 100% of need" means it covers that gap — it does not automatically mean you pay nothing, so check what's left for you.
- **student contribution** — The amount a US aid package expects *you* (not your parents) to contribute each year, usually from summer or term-time campus work. It is part of the package, so it is not covered by the grant.
- **need-blind** — The university decides admission *without* looking at whether you asked for financial aid — requesting aid can't hurt your chances.
- **need-aware** — Your ability to pay *can* factor into the admission decision — you still request aid, but it is a consideration.
- **CSS Profile** — The College Board's detailed financial-aid application most US universities use to assess your need (separate from the FAFSA). Opens 1 October.
- **IDOC** — College Board's Institutional Documentation Service — where you upload your parents' tax/income documents for financial aid.
- **PFAA** — **Princeton Financial Aid Application** — Princeton's own free aid form, filed in its applicant portal. Princeton uses it instead of the CSS Profile.
- **ISAFA** — **International Student Application for Financial Assistance** — Stanford's alternative aid form if you can't pay the CSS Profile fee.
- **fee waiver** — A request to cancel the application fee on the grounds of financial need — so you pay nothing to apply.
- **Common App** — The Common Application — one online form plus one main essay you reuse across many US universities.
- **self-report** — You type your own test scores into the application; you only pay to send official scores once you enrol.
- **supplement** — Extra, school-specific essay(s) on top of the shared Common App essay.
- **School Report** — A form (plus a letter) your school counsellor submits about you and your school.
- **mid-year report** — An update your school sends partway through the year with your latest grades.
- **I-20** — The US immigration form your university issues after you're admitted — you need it to apply for a student visa.

- **SAT** — A standardised US university-entrance exam; many US universities require the SAT or the ACT.
- **ACT** — A standardised US university-entrance exam; an accepted alternative to the SAT.
- **IELTS** — International English Language Testing System — an English-proficiency test. Your English-medium A-Levels waive it at many universities, but not all.
- **TOEFL** — Test of English as a Foreign Language — an English-proficiency test; an alternative to IELTS.
- **Yayasan Khazanah** — A Malaysian foundation offering competitive scholarships to study at top global universities.
- **DHS** — **Department of Homeland Security** — the US agency behind student visas; it publishes the list of degree codes that qualify for the STEM OPT extension.
- **OPT** — **Optional Practical Training** — US work permission that lets you work in your field for up to 12 months after graduating on a student visa.
- **STEM OPT** — **STEM OPT extension** — a 24-month extension of OPT for science/engineering degrees, giving up to 36 months of US work authorisation after you graduate.
- **CPT** — **Curricular Practical Training** — US work permission that lets you take an internship connected to your degree while you are still studying.
- **SEVIS** — **Student and Exchange Visitor Information System** — the US government database that tracks student-visa holders. Every applicant pays a one-off I-901 SEVIS fee before the visa interview.
- **E-Verify** — The US government system employers use to confirm a hire may legally work. Only an E-Verify employer can sponsor the 24-month STEM OPT extension.
- **USCIS** — **United States Citizenship and Immigration Services** — the US agency that decides immigration applications. You file OPT, STEM OPT and any extension of stay with USCIS, with a fee and a processing wait.
- **F-1** — The standard US student visa.

Sources

- Princeton — application dates and deadlines (SCEA 1 Nov, RD 1 Jan, PFAA 9 Nov / 1 Feb) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Princeton — standardized testing (test-optional; required from 2027-28) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Princeton — international students (English-test rule, need-blind) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Princeton — application checklist and FAQs (fee waiver, graded written paper) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Princeton — apply for aid, prospective students (PFAA only; no CSS Profile or IDOC) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Princeton — the student budget 2026-27 (USD 94,624) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures

- Princeton — cost and aid (family contribution by income; PFAA dates) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Princeton — financial aid FAQs (first-year work expectation) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Princeton — 2022 announcement ending the USD 3,500 student contribution (carried from the July guide; not re-read) — Official — as of 2022 announcement
- Harvard — first-year applicants (deadlines, USD 95 fee, testing, Harvard College Questions) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Harvard — apply for financial aid, prospective students (CSS 3434, IDOC, 2025 tax documents) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Harvard — application fee waivers — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Harvard — how aid works: cost of attendance 2026-27 (USD 91,634 billed) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Harvard — affordability (free at USD 100,000 or less; USD 3,500 work expectation; grants) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Yale — first-year application process and timelines (SCEA 1 Nov, RD 2 Jan) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Yale — standardized testing (SAT or ACT required; English-test rule) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Yale — prospective students' aid (international deadlines 1 Dec / 15 Feb; aid office contacts you) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Yale — financial aid FAQ (CSS Profile not required of international applicants; travel) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Yale — cost of attendance 2026-27 (USD 97,985) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Yale — affordability and terminology (zero parent share; Student Share USD 3,700) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Brown — application checklist (ED 1 Nov, RD 5 Jan, USD 80 fee, recommendations) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Brown — standardized tests (required; October / December cut-offs) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Brown — international financial aid (need-blind from the Class of 2029) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Brown — first-year international aid applicants (CSS 3189; 2 Nov 2026 / 1 Feb 2027; no CSS waiver) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Brown — cost of attendance 2026-27 (USD 99,994) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Brown — financial aid commitments (zero parent share under USD 60,000; no loans) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Stanford — first-year requirements and deadlines (REA 1 Nov, RD 5 Jan, USD 100 fee) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Stanford — testing (required; end-October / end-December SAT) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle

- Stanford — application fee and fee waiver — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Stanford — aid requirements, Regular Decision international (CSS 4704, ISAFA, 15 Feb) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Stanford — aid requirements, Restrictive Early Action international (15 Nov) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Stanford — international students and aid (limited aid; cannot apply later) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Stanford — undergraduate student budget 2026-27 (USD 97,545) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Stanford — student responsibility (at least USD 5,000) and parent contribution — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Penn — first-year applicants (ED 1 Nov 2026, RD 5 Jan 2027) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Penn — testing (required; latest SAT 7 Nov / 5 Dec 2026; English-test rule) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Penn — international student financial aid (need-aware; must apply with admission) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Penn — prospective international aid checklist 2027-28 (CSS 2933; no IDOC; 6 Nov / 5 Feb) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Penn — undergraduate cost of attendance 2026-27 (USD 99,082) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Columbia — first-year applicants (deadlines, USD 85 fee, recommendations) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Columbia — testing policy (test-optional 2026-2027; required from August 2027) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Columbia — international financial aid (need-aware; no second chance) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Columbia — cost of attendance 2026-2027 (USD 99,774) and affordability — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Cornell — first-year applicants (ED 1 Nov, RD 2 Jan, international aid dates, USD 85 fee) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Cornell — standardized testing policy (required; English-test rule) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Cornell — first-year international aid (CSS 2098; 1 Nov 2026 / 2 Jan 2027; need-aware; loans) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Cornell — cost to attend, endowed colleges (USD 99,734) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- Cornell Chronicle — trustees approve 2026-27 tuition and housing rates — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- MIT — first-year deadlines and requirements (EA 1 Nov, RA 4 Jan, test cut-offs, USD 75 fee) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- MIT — Early Action versus Regular Action (not restrictive; respects other schools' rules) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle

- MIT — applying for aid as an international student (CSS 3514, IDOC, translations) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- MIT — aid application deadlines (30 November / 15 February) — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- MIT — cost of attendance 2026-27 (USD 92,760) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- MIT — making MIT affordable, and outside scholarships (USD 5,400 student contribution) — Official — as of 2026-27 figures
- College Board — SAT dates and deadlines, 2026-27 — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- College Board — CSS Profile cost and fee waivers — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- US Department of State — student visa (I-20, DS-160, 365-day and 30-day rules) — Official — as of read 12 Oct 2026
- US Department of State — fees for visa services (USD 185) — Official — as of read 12 Oct 2026
- US Immigration and Customs Enforcement — I-901 SEVIS fee (USD 350) — Official — as of read 12 Oct 2026
- US Embassy in Malaysia — visas (interview waivers; social media set to public) — Official — as of read 12 Oct 2026
- USCIS — students and employment (no off-campus work in the first academic year) — Official — as of read 12 Oct 2026
- USCIS — OPT for F-1 students (filing windows, 12 months, 24-month STEM extension) — Official — as of read 12 Oct 2026
- USCIS — Form I-765 (court order of 14 Sept 2026 postponing the fixed-period rule; fee change 16 Oct 2026) — Official — as of read 12 Oct 2026
- DHS Study in the States — fixed time period of admission final rule, quick facts — Official — as of read 12 Oct 2026
- Stanford — application and essays (5 short questions, 3 short essays) — Official — as of read 16 Oct 2026
- Yale — essay topics for the 2026-27 cycle — Official — as of Fall-2027 cycle
- Yale — financial aid for international applicants (admissions page; CSS Profile line conflicts with the aid office) — Official — as of read 16 Oct 2026
- Brown — English proficiency (highly recommended; no years set) — Official — as of read 16 Oct 2026
- Columbia — English proficiency (all of secondary school in English, or SAT Reading and Writing 700+) — Official — as of read 16 Oct 2026